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VOL. 3 · ST. ANDREW SOUTH EAST

The Leader Who Lost Her Own Seat

Emmalin Pierre lost St. Andrew South East by 162 votes. She did not lose her own voters, whose number fell by just 44; she lost the race to find new ones, to a man she had beaten in 2022 and who never left the constituency.

BY GREG HOSTEN ST. ANDREW SOUTH EAST, GRENADA

ST. ANDREW SOUTH EAST, GRENADA— On election night the New National Party lost more than a government it had hoped to form: it lost its leader's seat. In St. Andrew South East, Education Minister David Andrew took 2,011 votes to 1,849 for Emmalin Pierre, the party's political leader and the woman who hoped to become Grenada's first female prime minister, with 19 for the DPM's Shirley McQueen. A margin of 162 votes ended a 13-year hold.

"She did not lose her voters. Her vote fell by 44. The NDC found 351 more."
GREG HOSTEN

The defeat is usually told as one chapter of the national landslide. The numbers tell a more specific story, and a more useful one for 2030/31: Ms. Pierre kept almost all of her 2022 voters, and the NDC simply found more of its own.

A SEAT THAT WAS SLIPPING FOR YEARS

St. Andrew South East, which takes in Grenville, Telescope, Soubise, Marquis, Crochu and Grand Bacolet, has never been safe for anyone. Ms. Pierre lost it to the NDC's Patrick Simmons by 30 votes in 2008, won it back in 2013, and defeated Mr. Simmons again in 2018 by 2,292 votes to 1,134, almost 67 per cent of the two-party vote.

Thereafter the margin began to erode. In 2022 she beat David Andrew by 1,893 to 1,660, a majority of 233, and her share of the two-party vote dropped to 53.3 per cent. Within four years a majority of 1,158 had shrunk by four-fifths. That was the warning; the party read it as a win.

THE LEADER IN A MARGINAL SEAT

Two years later the NNP chose Ms. Pierre as its political leader, at a convention on 15th December 2024 that was some two years overdue. Her rival, Peter David, withdrew hours before the vote, alleging that the process had been rigged, and left the party the following month. In March 2025 she became Leader of the Opposition.

The party's leader, national spokesperson and principal campaigner was thus sitting on a 233-vote majority. A party leader must spend the campaign everywhere; a marginal seat needs its candidate at home. In 2026 the NNP asked one person to do both, and gave the seat no visible plan to compensate for her absence.

THE MAN WHO STAYED

Mr. Andrew is a counselling therapist and educator who had served as a classroom teacher, guidance counsellor and Chief Education Officer. He lost to Ms. Pierre in 2022, but he did not move on. He went on to serve as Minister of Education, and when the next election came he was back on the same ballot, in the same seat, against the same opponent.

Set that beside St. George South, where the NNP has fielded four different candidates in four elections. The NDC's lesson from St. Andrew South East is that a losing candidate who stays becomes a winning one: four years of being known are worth more than any campaign.

SHE KEPT HER VOTERS. THEY FOUND MORE.

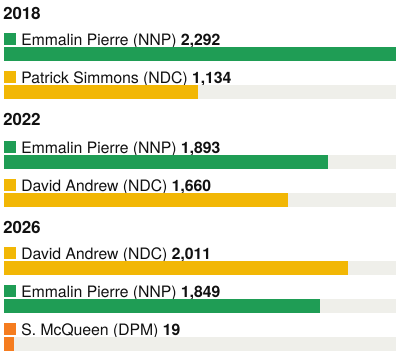
This is the most important number in the volume. Between 2022 and 2026, Ms. Pierre's vote fell by only 44, from 1,893 to 1,849, while Mr. Andrew's rose by 351, from 1,660 to 2,011. The NNP did not lose this seat to switchers; it lost it to new and returning NDC voters.

The register grew by 557 names over the four years, and 318 more ballots were cast, almost every additional vote going to the NDC. The NNP held its base and stood still, and in a growing constituency standing still amounts to losing.

Measured against the whole electorate, the picture is the same. In 2022 Ms. Pierre won the votes of 38.9 per cent of all registered

2018 VS 2022 VS 2026

Votes by candidate, in party colours



162 votes
NDC winning margin in 2026

BY THE NUMBERS

162
NDC winning margin, ending a 13-year NNP hold

82
Switchers the NNP needed to keep the seat

71.7%
Turnout, the highest of all 15 seats

–44
Change in the NNP vote since 2022, against +351 for the NDC

voters and Mr. Andrew 34.1 per cent; in 2026 her share fell to 34.1 per cent and his rose to 37.1 per cent. The two candidates traded places almost exactly.

SHE OUTRAN HER PARTY, AND STILL LOST

None of this means that Ms. Pierre ran a weak race in her own seat. Her share of the two-party vote fell 5.4 points, from 53.3 to 47.9 per cent, whereas the NNP fell 10.3 points nationally. She ran more than ten points ahead of her party, a clear sign of personal standing in St. Andrew South East.

A 233-vote majority, however, could not absorb even half the national swing. With the party's national vote falling as far as it did, the seat was lost the moment the NNP failed to grow its own vote there. The national campaign did not give her enough, and the local campaign did not find what was missing.

SEVEN DIVISIONS, AND THE KNIFE EDGE

The polling-division returns show a seat divided almost down the middle. The NNP carried 7 of the 16 divisions. Its strongest ground was Grand Bacolet, where it won 60.8 per cent of the two-party vote across two divisions, including one by 123 to 62; it also held Mamma Cannes and narrowly carried Telescope and Marquis.

The NDC won the seat in Grenville and its environs. At St. Andrew's Methodist School it took about 60 per cent across two divisions, and it did the same at Fort View, Mount Carmel. At the Crochu R.C. School it won 2 of 3 divisions.

Several divisions were decided by a handful of votes. The NNP won one Telescope division by 3 votes and Marquis by 8, but lost Post Royal by 9 and one Crochu division by 14. In a seat lost by 162, every one of those margins counts.

EIGHTY-TWO VOTERS

The most important number for the future is this. To have held the seat, the NNP needed 82 voters to switch sides, about five people in each of the 16 polling divisions, or 163 more of its own supporters to turn out, about one in ten of the 1,536 who stayed home.

Turnout here was 71.7 per cent, the highest in the country. These voters are engaged: they came out, they listened, and a few more of them were persuaded by the other side. This is a seat that can be won back through organisation and presence, without any change in the national mood.

A CAMPAIGN THAT NEVER CAUGHT FIRE

The national picture explains part of the loss. The NDC called the election nearly a year before it was due, leaving the opposition little more than a month of formal campaigning, and the NNP's offer, including a promise to remove VAT on sugar within 90 days, did not cut through. After the results, the Barbados-based political scientist Peter Wickham suggested that Ms. Pierre should consider stepping down to allow the party to renew itself.

Whether or not one agrees, the point for St. Andrew South East is narrower. A leader's seat should be the best-run campaign in the party, with its own manager, its own volunteers and its own budget, so that the leader is free to travel. There is no public sign that this seat had any of these.

WHAT CAN BE DONE: A FOUR-YEAR PLAN FOR THE SOUTH-EAST

St. Andrew South East is the most winnable seat the NNP lost. It requires 82 switchers, not a political earthquake, and the necessary steps follow directly from the numbers.

Year one, 2027: decide early, and in public, who the candidate will be, whether Ms. Pierre or a successor, and commit to that person through to polling day. If the candidate is also the party leader, appoint a full-time constituency manager and a deputy who campaigns locally whenever the leader is away. Open a permanent office in Grenville.

Year two, 2028: concentrate on Grenville itself, where the St. Andrew's Methodist School and Fort View divisions gave the NDC about 60 per cent. Hold regular meetings with Grenville's vendors, bus operators, the fishers of Soubise and young families, and build a short local programme from what they say. Register new voters every month, because the register grew by 557 in four years and the NDC found most of them.

Year three, 2029: give each of the 16 polling divisions a captain, with particular attention to the knife-edge divisions at Telescope, Marquis, Post Royal and Crochu. Hold the sitting member to account in public, measured against the government's own promises for St. Andrew.

Year four, 2030: campaign on numbers that are within reach. Hold Grand Bacolet and Mamma Cannes, win back Telescope and Crochu, narrow the gap in Grenville, and find 82 switchers or 163 new supporters. No other seat the NNP lost offers so small a target.

THE LESSON FOR EVERY NNP SEAT

A shrinking majority is a warning, not a win. The NNP held St. Andrew South East in 2022 by 233 votes and treated the result as safe enough to make its member the party leader. Four years later the NDC had found 351 new votes, and the leader was out of Parliament.

The NDC's method here was simple: keep the losing candidate, give him a public role, and spend four years adding voters. The NNP can adopt the same method, beginning with the seat where it needs the fewest votes of all.

THE ARITHMETIC OF ST. ANDREW SOUTH EAST

Measure	2018	2022	2026
NNP votes	2,292	1,893	1,849
NDC votes	1,134	1,660	2,011
NNP share of two-party vote	66.9%	53.3%	47.9%
NNP two-party share nationally		48.0%	37.7%
Winning margin	NNP +1,158	NNP +233	NDC +162
Registered voters		4,868	5,425
Turnout		73.4%	71.7% (highest of 15)
Registered voters who did not vote		1,297	1,536
NNP votes as a share of all registered voters		38.9%	34.1%
Polling divisions won by the NNP			7 of 16
Switchers the NNP needed to win			82

Two-party figures exclude minor candidates. 2026: DPM 19. 2026 figures are provisional results from the Parliamentary Elections Office, all 16 polling divisions verified. 2018 NDC candidate: Patrick Simmons.

WHAT IT MEANS FOR 2030/31

1. A shrinking majority is a warning: 1,158 became 233, then a defeat.
2. A leader in a marginal seat needs a full-time local campaign behind her.
3. Keep a losing candidate who stays: the NDC did, and won.
4. Holding the base is not enough when the register is growing.
5. Register new voters every month: the NDC found most of the 557.
6. Win Grenville, or at least narrow it: it decided this seat.
7. Captain the knife-edge divisions: Telescope, Marquis, Post Royal, Crochu.
8. Target 82 switchers: the smallest gap of any seat the NNP lost.

Sources: Parliamentary Elections Office live results, live.elections.gd (2026, provisional; polling divisions read 9 Nov 2026); NOW Grenada (2026 results, 6 Nov 2026; 'One seat, many questions', 6 Nov 2026; NNP convention, 15 Dec 2024; Peter David resignation, 21 Jan 2025; 2022 official results); Jamaica Gleaner / CMC (6 Nov 2026); NDC (2022 candidate profile); Caribbean National Weekly (NNP convention, Jun 2026); Wikipedia (Emmalin Pierre; 2022 general election). Analytics computed by the author from the published counts. Analysis by Greg Hosten, Vol. 3 of a weekly constituency series. Written in the style of a newspaper report; not a publication of any news organisation.